

MAGIC IN THE AIR



PARA GLIDING SPOT ■ BILLING, HIMACHAL PRADESH

This is the time of the year when the azure sky of the Kangra valley in Himachal Pradesh is filled with floating specks of colour. For Billing, a 2,320-metre-high feature, it's time to welcome another set of paragliders from around the world. Against the backdrop of the Dhauladhar mountains, they spread their chutes at the take-off point. They wait for a waft of wind to inflate their chutes before taking the plunge, filling the sky with colour and excitement. A micro-climate ideal for gliding, abundant landing sites, inexpensive flying and good connectivity are the factors that have put Billing on the adventure tourism map. Another factor is the profusion of air thermals—wafts of hot air that cyclically rise up from the sun-bathed landscape and mountain slopes—which the gliders use to sail and gain height. The professional fliers call it the “magic air of Billing”. The Kangra autumn (mid-October to mid-November) is the best season as the wind-velocity during the day is steady and allows paragliding for four to five hours at a stretch. Paragliders often fly distances as long as 150 km at heights of 5,500 metres across the Dhauladhar range. “The Billing weather is reliably good for assured flying for a month, a rarity at other spots,” says Swiss flier John Oberson. From half-a-dozen gliders in 1995, Billing now sees around 130 fliers passing through in autumn and around 50 in spring (mid-March to mid-April). Clearly, Billing’s global popularity has taken wings.

by Ramesh Vinayak

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